

syllabus

Introduction to Early Latin America

HILA 255/LAC 251

TR 11:20-12:35

HSS 123

FALL 2025

Prof. Chad Black

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Course Description

In 1492, Columbus sailed the ocean blue and discovered or destroyed, conquered or civilized the Americas. Sixty years later, in 1552, López de Gómara, the private secretary of Hernán Cortes, wrote, “The greatest event since the creation of the world (excluding the incarnation and death of Him who created it) is the discovery of the Indies [i.e. Americas].” He was, himself, a participant the conquest of Mexico. From the very beginning, not only the magnitude, but also the meaning of the Conquest of the Americas has been a point of controversy and

acclaim. The history of Early Latin America, however, does not begin in October 1492. Indigenous bands and great civilizations inhabited North and South America for more than ten thousand years prior to the arrival of Europeans on the shores of Caribbean islands. Thus, in this class we will concentrate on the pre-Colombian period, the conquest period, and the ensuing three hundred years of Spanish (and to a limited extent) Portuguese rule. The lectures will move both chronologically and topically. We will concentrate on two key geographic areas of examination— central Mexico, home to the highly structured pre-Columbian societies of the Maya and the Mexica, among many others, and later the center of Spanish control in its northern kingdoms as the Viceroyalty of New Spain; and, the central Andes, land of the Inca Empire and its subject polities (among others), and home of the Viceroyalty of Peru, the center of Spanish power in its southern kingdoms. Our class will cover a tremendous breadth of time and territory, and as such the lectures, readings, and discussion sections are designed to draw your critical attention to issues, including ethnicity, gender, slavery, culture, and power, as well as the institutions and structures that patterned native, African, and European experiences of Spanish and Portuguese imperialism.

Course Objectives

1. To introduce students to the forces, events, and conflicts that defined the process of conquest and colonization of the Americas, including:
 - The histories and cultures of pre-conquest state systems, particularly in central Mexico and the Andes.
 - The historical precedents for Spanish and Portuguese expansion and conquest.
 - The process of conquest and colonization from the perspectives of Iberian, African, and indigenous populations.
 - The fundamental forms of institutional and cultural organization that structured daily life during the three centuries of Spanish rule.
 - The tensions of late colonial society that led to conflict, disorder, and eventually rebellion.
2. To understand and use a variety of sources that provide the core of historical inquiry.
3. To be able to identify, understand, and critique historical argument.
 - Historians follow a loose set of epistemological, theoretical, and evidentiary rules in their attempts to recreate the limited past that is accessible to us through our incomplete archival record. At the college level and beyond, it is your task to learn how to identify an author's central argument and to evaluate it based on its evidence, sources, logic, and narrative.

Course Requirements

Students are required to engage in this class. Learning is an interactive process, and requires active participation by all members of the class. Students need to read, write, and attend class in order to be successful. These [[assignments]] are designed to contribute to the overall objectives of the semester, including both content-specific and skill-based goals. We also have a weekly [[calendar]] with specific topics and readings.

Policies

Accommodations: Qualified students with disabilities needing appropriate academic adjustments should contact me as soon as possible to ensure that your needs are met in a timely manner with appropriate documentation.

Attendance: Attendance at all class sessions is mandatory. If you cannot attend, please email Dr. Black or your TA ahead of time. Make sure to sign the attendance sheet with your TA.

Deadlines: Assignments must be turned in by the end of class on the day they are due, unless otherwise instructed or arranged with the professor. Late papers will not be accepted without **prior arrangement**, for any reason. This includes technology problems.

Cell Phones and Laptops: Please silence cell phones during to class. Please do not text during class. Cell phones ought to be put away for the duration of our meetings. Laptops are allowed only for tasks related to this class. Distracting use of technology (social media, surfing, GroupMe chats, etc.) causes problems not only for your own learning, but for those around you. Research shows that analog note-taking improves learning. Consider having paper with you. Based on the prevailing literature, hand note-taking— both while reading and in class— leads to substantially better educational outcomes. You are not required to have a laptop in class, so feel free to leave it at home. If, however, you have reason to use your laptop for note-taking, I won't stop you from doing so.

Plagiarism and Academic Honesty: Plagiarism occurs when someone knowingly or unknowingly presents the words or ideas of another person, chatbot, or large language model as his or her own. Any work turned in for this class must meet University standards for academic honesty. Any students unsure about how to apply these rules are urged to consult with me prior to turning in any written work. To repeat, all work you turn in must be your own, and not another student's or produced by AI. Do not submit work produced by or with the assistance of LLMs, for example generative AI such as chatGPT, grok, Gemini, Copilot, Claude, etc. The assignments in this course are designed to teach you how to think and reason like a historian. Writing is thinking. If someone or something else is doing your writing, it's also doing your thinking. Except that LLMs do not think. They are not search engines, databases, or indices of the

web or human knowledge. They are very sophisticated statistical models that generate sequences of words or phrases that are indifferent to truth.

Drop In Office Hours: Students are strongly encouraged to speak with me and the TAs outside of class. The advantages include: extra help on an assignment or preparation for an exam; clarification of materials covered in lecture, discussion of my comments on your work; discussion of this or related courses. We are available during office hours on a first-come, first-served basis; if you cannot come by during office hours, please contact me via email or phone and I will be happy to set up an appointment with you.

Changes: I reserve the right to change this syllabus as the semester progresses. This is not a contract, but rather a document to guide expectations and clearly communicate weekly assignments. Please bring the syllabus with you to our class meetings. Or, keep up with it on the course website.

required readings

This course requires a reading for each class meeting. Readings are available on Canvas or through the library website. There are no books to buy. The assigned reading is listed for each day on the [[calendar]].

attendance (20%)

Students must sign the attendance sheet of their TA for each class meeting.

in-class writing (20%)

Occasionally, at the end of class, you will be asked to write a short paragraph on the day's or week's readings. You get two free misses for any reason whatsoever. But this also means that any misses over two will count regardless of excuses. In other words, don't do what some have in the past: skip two classes and then get sick for a third, because that third miss will count. You may use one page of handwritten notes for in-class writing.

in-class exams (20% each)

There will be two exams— a midterm and a final.

film reaction (20%)

We have three feature-length film options this semester— **La otra conquista**, **Zama**, and **The Mission**. Students must write a 3-5 page analysis of one of these films. The analysis must compare the film to an assigned reading from

this semester. There are specific instructions for each film to help you under [\[\[Course Resources\]\]](#).

Week 1 (Let us begin. What, where, why, or when?)

[!info] Welcome (back) to the History of Early Latin America. This week, your first responsibility is to carefully read over the pages on this website, the course requirements, and to plan for your participation in class! Make sure you understand what the coursework requirements are, and also some general recommendations on how to read, take notes, and think about weekly material.

This is quite obviously a very lecture intensive class. Your lecture notes will be very important for your weekly assignments. If you struggle with note-taking, or have never taken a humanities lecture course before, you will need to think about, and put effort into improving your [\[\[/resources/an-approach-to-making-notes|note-taking\]\]](#). Take a look at these resources, and find a system that works best for you:

1. Effective Note-taking in Lectures.
2. The Pen is Mightier than the Keyboard.
3. How to Take Better Notes.

In addition to taking notes during lecture, you need to be an active reader of the pieces we're assigning. This means using either paper or pdf tools to highlight and markup the assignments. A very good exercise for your other classes and future engagement with difficult academic texts is to try to write a [\[\[/resources/how to write a précis and memo|précis and memo\]\]](#) for every chapter, article, source, or book that you read. We will be discussing this over the course of the semester, especially how to approach strange texts with unfamiliar concepts.

Your most fundamental skill for this semester will be creatively connecting the lectures and the readings, looking for thematic similarities or arguments both within a week's topic and between weeks. Make sure to look at each week's title, and the brief comments comment for the week to help follow the arc of the semester.

Tuesday, August 19, 2025: The Time of History

- Read the website/syllabus very carefully!

Thursday, August 21, 2025: On Sedentary Societies

[!question] Reading question How does the organization of exchange effect or reflect other aspects of a given society? What does Karatani mean by 'mode of exchange'? What are the basic modes of exchange

that he identifies? What values do they represent? Can you imagine current examples of those modes at work?

- Karatani, Kojin. *The Structure of World History*. Duke University Press. Pp. 5-10, 35-49. Library copy. If that link doesn't work, try this one

Week 2 (Premodern Societies)

[!info] Week two focus. The immigrants to what we now call the Americas arrived by land and cruising the coasts. The civilizations that evolved from their wanderings were highly complex and advanced. This week, we are considering their emergence, and the revolutionary domestication of Zea mays that made it possible. To this day, there is no single crop or animal more central to the US economy and its food system than corn.

Tuesday, August 26, 2025 : The Persistence of Semi-Sedentary Living

- Townsend, Camila. (2021) *Fifth Sun: A New History of the Aztecs*. Oxford University Press. Pp 1-32.

Thursday, August 28, 2025: Maya

- Thompson, J. Eric. "The Meaning of Maize for the Maya." in Gilbert M. Joseph and Timothy J. Henderson, eds., *The Mexico Reader: History, Culture, Politics* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2002), pp. 86-91.
- Anonymous. "The Popol Vuh." In Joseph and Henderson, eds., *The Mexico Reader*, pp. 79-85.
- Please watch this short video that animates part of the Popol vuh. ##
Week 3 (Premodern Societies II)

[!info] Week two focus. The collapse of Classical Maya society did not mean the disappearance of the Maya. Indeed, Maya-speaking communities continue to form integral parts of Mexican and Guatemalan society today, along with other Central American states. This week, we consider the successors and inheritors of the Mesoamerican cultural world once dominated by the Maya, with the rise of the Mexica in the central valley of Mexico. Then, we turn to South America for an introduction to the third great sedentary empire of the pre-Conquest period, the Inka of the Andes. As you read and attend lecture this week, consider the influence of environmental factors on the emergence of these civilizations along with their religious and social practices.

Tuesday, September 2, 2025: Mexica

- Townsend, Camila. (2021). *Fifth Sun*. Oxford University Press, pp. 33-58.

Thursday, September 4, 2025: Inka

- Strong, Mary. (2012). *Art, Nature, and Religion in the Central Andes*. University of Texas Press. Pp. 17-58.

Week 4 (Premodern Societies III)

[!info] Week four focus. With a foundation in the pre-Conquest Americas, this week we turn to the Iberian Peninsula, the close-in Atlantic islands, and to Africa to look at the roots of conquest in the so-called “Old World.” Consider the culture of conquest cultivated by Isabella and Ferdinand in the 1490s, and also what lessons Iberians learned of conquest and expansion in their control of Atlantic Islands and the trade in enslaved captives with West Africa.

Tuesday, September 9, 2025: Iberias.

- “Las Siete Partidas: Laws on Jews.”
- “King Ferdinand, Marriage Concessions (1469)” in Jon Cowans, ed. *Early Modern Spain: A Documentary History* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2003): 7-9.
- “Surrender Treaty of the Kingdom of Granada (1491)” in Cowans, *Early Modern Spain*: 15-19.
- “Decree of Expulsion of the Jews (1492)” in Cowans, *Early Modern Spain*: 20-23.

Thursday, September 11, 2025: Africa is not a country

- Thornton, John K. 2012. “The African Background,” *A Cultural History of the Atlantic World, 1250–1820*. Cambridge Univ. Press. Pp 60-100.

Week 5 (The Early Conquest)

[!info] Week five focus. Prior to sailing across the Atlantic, Columbus learned from Portuguese and Spanish expansion into the Atlantic Islands and down the coast of Africa economic models for colonial exploitation. Conquering and enslaving native populations, importing captive Africans for enslaved labor, cultivating sugar for export to Europe, and improving sea-going technology were all in place before he received Royal support. This week, we look at the transplantation of an Atlantic model of conquest and exploitation to the Caribbean, and at its religious critics. Pay close attention to the arguments made by Friars Montesinos, and Pane, and whether they offer an alternative colonial model, or an alternative to colonialism?

Tuesday, September 16, 2025: Caribbean Conquests

- Christopher Columbus’s Log, excerpted in English. Focus on period after Oct. 11.
- The Requerimiento

Thursday, September 18, 2025: The Critique

- Antonio Montesinos, “Advent Sermon”
- “The Relación of Fray Ramón Pane (c. 1494-1496)”

Week 6 (On the Mainland)

[!info] Week six focus.

In the 1520s and 1530s, the Spanish Empire expanded to cover much of Central and South America. At the time, Spaniards and their native allies both imagined themselves as conquering the controlling empires of Mesoamerica and the Andes. Who, then, conquered whom? In the early 16th century, did native allies with the Spanish imagine themselves as collaborators in European domination? If not, what did they imagine they were doing?

Tuesday, September 23, 2025: Conquest Myths and Realities

- Townsend, Camila. (2021). *Fifth Sun*. Oxford University Press. Pp 107-128.
- “The Spaniards’ Entry into Tenochtitlan,” *The Mexico Reader*. Pp. 97-104.

Thursday, September 25, 2025: From the Planes of Cajamarca

- Seed, Patricia. (1991). “Failing to Marvel: Atahualpa’s Encounter with the Word.” *Latin American Research Review* (26.1): 7-32. UTK Library

Week 7 (The Order of Things)

[!info] Week seven focus. How do you build an empire in the midst of demographic collapse? How do you survive the imposition of a new symbolic order? How did the institutional framework of empire work to create a new culture/society that subsumed its constituent parts (and what does that sentence mean)? How did early modern imperialists confront the technical and practical challenges of ruling the span of the globe?

Tuesday, September 30, 2025: Building on Collapsing Ground

- Phelan, John Leddy. (June 1960). “Authority and Flexibility in the Spanish Imperial Bureaucracy” *Administrative Science Quarterly*, Vol. 5, No. 1, Special Issue on Comparative Public Administration. Pp. 47-65. UTK Library

Thursday, October 2, 2025: Church in State

- Nesvig, Martin. (2021) *Promiscuous Power*, “Burning Down the House, in Which the spiritual Conquistadors Go to War with Each Other.” University of Texas Press.

Week 8 (Fall Break and Midterm Exam)

Tuesday, October 7, 2025: Fall Break

You know what to do.

Thursday, October 9, 2025: In-Class

Be sure to bring a blue or green exam booklet with you for the exam. You can buy one at any of the Pods. They are very, very cheap.

Week 9 (Captivity and Enslavements)

[!info] Week nine focus. From its inception, the Spanish and Portuguese colonial projects depended on the labor of enslaved Africans and Indigenous people. Formally, Indigenous slavery was abolished early by the crown. But African captivity was a mainstay of the Spanish and Portuguese imperial projects. As Kris Lane argues, slave owners even pinned their hopes for the afterlife on enslaved labor carried out in their name after death. Pay close attention this week to strategies that enslaved and free blacks pursued in colonial Latin America.

Tuesday, October 14, 2025: A Society Built on Enslavement

- Lane, Kris. (2000) "Captivity and Redemption: Aspects of Slave Life in early Colonial Quito and Popoyan." *The Americas* 57.2. Pp 225-246. UTK Library

Thursday, October 16, 2025: Brazilian Trajectories

- Jane Landers, "Felipe Edimboro Sues for Manumission, Don Francisco Xavier Sánchez contests (Florida, 1794)," in *Colonial Lives*, pp. 249-268.

Week 10 (Native Labor and Accumulation)

[!info] Week 10 focus. Enslavement was not the only form of coerced labor exploited by Iberian empires. This week we consider the effects of encomienda and tribute on the integrity of native communities under Iberian rule. What significance is there in native communities pursuing their own legal strategies before the crown? How did tribute taxation and labor function? Were the New Laws successful?

Tuesday, October 21, 2025: The Many Kinds of Economic Coercion

- Barragán, Rossana. (2017). "Working Silver for the World: Mining Labor and Popular Economy in Colonial Potosí." *Hispanic American Historical Review* (97.2): 193-222. UTK Library

Thursday, October 23, 2025: Wither the Two Republics?

- Yannakakis, Yanna. “Taking the Courts to the Fields: Law, Violence, and Agrarian Custom in Colonial Oaxaca, Mexico.” *Law and history review*. (20.3): 513-532. UTK Library

Week 11 (Love, Hate, and Social Reproduction)

[!info] Week 11 focus. This week, we are focusing on family, sexuality, and social order. The customs and laws of Iberia and the Indies were deeply influential in the ordering (and disordering) of colonial society. The Conquest, and its aftermath, included exploitative and coercive relationships, and even regular marriages had their fair share of conflict between spouses. This week, we consider these things by looking at unnatural sexuality and witchcraft, as a way of also understanding what colonial society understood to be natural.

****Tuesday, October 28, 2025: Is It Love or Is It Magic?**

- Ruth Behar, “Sexual Witchcraft, Colonialism, and Women’s Powers,” in *Sexuality and Marriage in Colonial Latin America*. Lavrin, ed. Lincoln: Univ. of Nebraska Press, 1992.

Thursday, October 30, 2025: Sex in the Archive

- Black, Chad. “Negotiating Adultery in Colonial Quito,” Pp 171-179 in *The Routledge Companion to Sexuality and Colonialism* ## Week 12 (Film Review)

Tuesday, November 4, 2025: Election Day, No Class

Thursday, November 6, 2025: No Class

Finish your film review, which must be smart, clever, and plugged into this semester’s themes rather than AI slop.

Week 13 (Rebellion and Reaction)

[!info] Week 13 focus. By the 1780s, part of the Spanish Empire erupted into open rebellion against the economic reforms pushed after the Seven Years War. Why did these rebellions not lead to Independence? What explains the complicated political identities articulated by their protagonists? What constituted legitimate authority by century’s end?

Tuesday, November 11, 2025: Reform Reactions

- Pamela Voekel, “Peeing on the Palace: Bodily Resistance to Bourbon Reforms in Mexico City,” *Journal of Historical Sociology*, Vol. 5 No. 2 (June 1992): 183-208. UTK Library

Thursday, November 13, 2025: Insurrections down South

- David T. Garrett, “His Majesty’s Most Loyal Vassals”: The Indian Nobility and Túpac Amaru,” *Hispanic American Historical Review*, 84:4 (2004): 575-617. UTK Library

Week 14 (Independence)

[!info] Week 14 focus. The crises of the Bourbon reforms never produced independence movements. That would take Napoleon invading Spain. We consider this week the crisis of 1808 caused by Napoleon, and how that set up the process of independence, which wouldn’t culminate for more than a decade!

Tuesday, November 18, 2025: The Horror of Politics

- Chad Thomas Black (2025) On private and public violence: Joseph García de León y Pizarro’s ideology of rule (1780), *Colonial Latin American Review*, 34:2, 235-257. UTK Library

Thursday, November 20, 2025: Did You See it Coming?

- Jaime E. Rodríguez O., “New Spain and the 1808 Crisis of Spanish Monarchy,” *Mexican Studies/Estudios Mexicanos*, 24.2 (Summer 2008): 245-287. UTK Library

Week 15 (Thanksgiving)

[!tip] No class this week!

Tuesday, November 25, 2025

- Travel safely.

Thursday, November 27, 2025

- Eat food and manage family.

Week 16 (WRAP IT UP!)

[!danger] WRAP. It. Up. The new republics will be free of Iberian rule, and you’re about to be free of this semester....

Tuesday, December 2, 2025

- No reading for our final meeting.

Final Exam: Tuesday December 9 at 3:30pm.